Approve and deploy an enterprise AI service, any vendor

A vendor-neutral runbook for taking one AI service from request to production: intake, use-case and data classification, contract and data-processing checks, a go / conditional go / no-go decision record, identity and connector scoping, a safe pilot, launch, incident revocation and reapproval.

10 phases | 16 steps | Tick each item when its "done when" criterion is true

Phase 1 Intake: business need, owner and request about 1–3 days

- [ ] **1.1 Capture the request with the intake checklist**
  Every intake field below is answered or explicitly marked unknown

Phase 2 Classify the use case and the data about 1–2 days

- [ ] **2.1 Place the use case on the chat → RAG → agent ladder**
  Use pattern, connected systems and permitted actions are documented and agreed by the technical owner
- [ ] **2.2 Classify data and decide the risk tier**
  Allowed and prohibited data classes are listed, and the tier (low / medium / high) is recorded with a reason

Phase 3 Vendor, contract and data-processing evaluation about 1–3 weeks

- [ ] **3.1 Collect plan-specific evidence, not marketing claims**
  Each question has an answer with a source document, version or date, and the plan it applies to
- [ ] **3.2 Put the processing relationship in writing**
  Signed contract and DPA (or equivalent) exist, or the decision is blocked

Phase 4 Proportionate privacy, security and legal checks about 1–4 weeks

- [ ] **4.1 Run the checks the tier requires**
  Each required check is complete or recorded as a blocker

Phase 5 Decision: go, conditional go or no-go about 1–2 days

- [ ] **5.1 Complete the approval decision record**
  Record is signed by the named approver roles and stored with the evidence

Phase 6 Identity, access and connector scoping about 2–5 days

- [ ] **6.1 Lock down identity and lifecycle**
  SSO and MFA are enforced, access is group-based, and leavers lose access through the normal deprovisioning path
- [ ] **6.2 Scope connectors, keys and agent tools**
  Every connector and tool has a documented scope, a service identity and an owner

Phase 7 Safe pilot with exit criteria about 2–6 weeks

- [ ] **7.1 Run the pilot on approved data and test the controls**
  Pilot group, data scope and test plan are documented, and tests are executed and recorded
- [ ] **7.2 Apply pilot exit criteria**
  Each criterion is met, waived by the approver with a reason, or the pilot ends

Phase 8 Controlled launch: policy, training, monitoring, cost about 1–2 weeks

- [ ] **8.1 Launch in rings with guidance and monitoring**
  Policy published, training delivered, monitoring and cost alerts in place before each ring

Phase 9 Incident response, rollback and troubleshooting about Prepare: 1 day

- [ ] **9.1 Pause and revoke**
  Runbook names who can execute each step, and it has been walked through once
- [ ] **9.2 Troubleshoot common failures narrowly**
  Each fix keeps the control intact

Phase 10 Periodic reapproval and change triggers about Recurring

- [ ] **10.1 Review on a schedule and on triggers**
  Expiry date set, triggers documented, and a reviewer named
- [ ] **10.2 Worked example (fictional): a contract-summary RAG assistant**
  Reader can map each phase to the example

Owner	Change / ticket	Date completed

Original checklist by Tenant Recipes, an independent project not affiliated with Microsoft or any vendor. Every step, its actions, pitfalls and the official sources it was checked against are on https://tenantrecipes.com/guides/enterprise-ai-service-approval.html. Time estimates are our own planning figures. Confirm against the linked sources and test in a pilot before production.